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The Matter of Words

On the Work of Philippe Tougard-Maucotel

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I. BIOGRAPHICALLY

Philippe Tougaard-Maucotel

subsculptor, born April 27, 1940, France – died December 27, 2020, Cutchogue, Long Island, USA

He was born in France. He graduated from the Sorbonne in Paris and later became an American of French descent. The first important creative works he presented to a wider audience were two volumes of poetry: *L'Étrave* (French for "the stem," the forward part of a ship's hull), published in Paris in 1960, and *Tel Quel* (French for "as it is," "in its original form"), published in 1963. He also translated Mircea Eliade's book *No Souvenirs* (French for "No Memories").

He was a friend of Raymond Hains, co-founder of the *Nouveau Réalisme* ("New Realism") movement, established in 1960. Other members included Arman, François Dufrêne, Yves Klein, Jean Tinguely, Jacques Villeglé, and Pierre Restany. Among his friends were also Christo and Gérard Deschamps.

In 1972 he purchased a brownstone in Brooklyn. In one interview he joked that after buying it he could no longer afford the art collection with which he might have filled it, so he began creating his own. He was thirty-nine years old when he embarked upon his sculptural practice.

From the sculptor Philip Pavia (1911–2005), associated with Abstract Expressionism, he purchased a studio in a barn on the North Fork. At the same time, from 1968 onward, he lived in nearby Cutchogue, where he died in 2020 at the age of eighty.

In the name of the town of Cutchogue on Long Island he saw the potential for an important linguistic game. He read the first element of the name—*cut*—as a foretelling of his own destiny as a "cutter" of letters. Blades and cutting tools were associated in his mind with the sharpness of language. He himself spoke of the *bad blade*, creating a pun referring simultaneously to a sharp tool and a "sharp tongue."

He emphasized that he remained, first and foremost, a poet. He wrote poems first, and only later, from a need to express more—"by accident"—did he begin cutting out words. It was as though what the word offered as an abstract, written, literary symbol had ceased to be enough for him. Perhaps he sought greater materialization, fuller expression, an increase in the number of contexts in which words could appear—not only within a text, alongside other words and meanings, but also within the context of nature, the elements, situations, an accidentally appearing audience, and the spaces of the studio and the home. Letters, words, entire sentences displayed in space seemed to become more interesting through the various interactions to which they were subjected, and to possess greater poetic potential than when confined to the two-dimensional surface of paper. Thus he transformed his creative medium from language written on paper into spatial lexical—or literary—objects, while remaining a creator of words.

He cast the physical forms of words in concrete, carved them in wood, plywood, and metal, and assembled them from found objects and natural materials, for example from compressed bales of hay, from which he created the large inscription *Hay* ("hay"; also a pun on *hey*).

The material in which he embodied the word served to emphasize its meaning and to expand the possibilities of the linguistic play that he pursued without respite.

The link between Philippe Tougard-Maucotel's poetic expression and the expression of his spatial forms is the artist's handwriting. The artist's realized language, composed of three-dimensional letters, words, and entire verbal games, often takes the form of enlarged handwritten text. Philippe's handwriting, however, is not particularly elaborate. It reveals neither exceptional calligraphic skill nor eccentric inclinations. One might describe it as legible, neat, and balanced.

Through this device, the artist's original gesture—the trace of Maucotel's hand—is preserved in his works in a manner characteristic of him, namely an indirect one. The viewer perceives only the symbol of the gesture—the enlarged personal letters and drawings—because what actually constitutes the gesture itself, namely the path of the jigsaw used to shape the letterforms, remains neutral and is, in fact, of little significance to the perception of the work's visual form.

Living in a foreign country is an exile into... the individual meanings of words, he observed. You rediscover words when you speak another language. You are never a member of the family of a foreign language, he claimed. Nevertheless, he considered English a language well suited to creative work, rich in vocabulary, slang, and more open to manipulation than French, which he described as *respectful, restrictive and grammatically correct*.

The word meant a great deal to him—whether spoken or written. Good conversation and laughter mattered. *My symptom and amusement is my muse*, he would say. Maucotel could work only on ideas that amused him and, in turn, amused others. It had to be playful, light. He created puns. He regarded the viewer's smile as his artistic success. The effort required to read the content of the work and uncover the meaning hidden beneath the surface of the words was rewarded with good humour—the desired outcome of his artistic game. *He wants to have fun. I do have fun*.

He was a friend of the French New Realists and of concrete poets. He declared his admiration for Duchamp and Dadaism. As a poet, he valued meaning more than form. He described himself as both a conceptual artist and a Surrealist, but perhaps it would be truest to say that he regarded himself as separate from all artistic trends. He jokingly referred to himself as a *subsculptor*. In keeping with this idea, he created a work—a three-dimensional rendering of the word *subsculptor*, buried halfway in the ground. The partial burial of the word should be understood as a symbolic transfer of meaning beneath the surface. One gains the impression that, when it came to artistic identity, he never stepped into the same river twice, but instead continually rearranged his understanding of his own artistic self.

He created a life abundant in inhabited and visited spaces, and rich in experiences, literature, poetry, encounters, relationships—and therefore in conversations, texts written, read, and spoken. He played the game of life lightly.

He happened to be in the right places at the right times. He met many wise and fascinating people—artists and poets—who became his wonderful interlocutors. He enjoyed social good fortune without aggressively striving for great fame. Professionally, he worked in education, teaching language and literature at various institutions. Between 1967 and 1983, among other positions, he served as Head of the Department of Foreign Languages at the Packer Collegiate Institute in New York. Working in educational institutions, he naturally expanded his circle of acquaintances... and of exchanged ideas. At the same time, with a smile and a sense of distance, he observed his own coincidences. At times he immersed himself deeply in reflection; at others he merely skimmed joyfully across the surface of meanings. One may conclude that, having fulfilled in life everything people usually desire, he

devoted himself to the original creative idea of materializing the word. For in the beginning was the Word.

He left behind more than two hundred spatial words in Cutchogue.

II. THE MATERIALIZATION OF WORDS

Naming Space and the Physical Presence of Words. *The Matter of Words / Words in the World*

Philippe Maucotel created numerous intimate sculptures that become part of the interiors of his studio and home. They engage furniture and everyday objects in such a way that it is never entirely clear where the artwork begins and the object ends. He most likely did not treat all of these elements and their mutual relationships with the reverence usually reserved for museum exhibits. They simply constituted part of the interior. The letters he cut from various materials appeared throughout the space and penetrated the very fabric of the house. The same occurred within the fabric of the garden, where larger-scale works came into being.

The letters also extended onto the fence and beyond the boundaries of the property, as in the concrete inscription *Oubli* (French for "forgetfulness"), submerged just off the shore of Long Island. Depending on the mood of the sea, the letters forming the word emerge from the water or disappear beneath the waves, creating a metaphor for human memory.

Works woven into the domestic environment include, for example, letters placed on the lawn or formed from white gravel so that the inscription can be read only from a bird's-eye view, as well as freestanding forms of various sizes, immediately recognizable as works displayed in space.

From the occupation of the surrounding environment by spatial words and letters—appearing at different scales, throughout different parts of the site, and interacting with its structure in various ways—emerges the idea of making oneself at home. The artist creates an environment congenial to himself, while at the same time controlling and organizing it. Naming makes the world more comprehensible. It is also an act of transforming seriousness into play, through which space acquires the qualities of the artist himself. Together, they create a new meaning. It is as though Philippe Maucotel were establishing the rules governing his own republic, one in which a particular language prevails—a language fixed in matter.

The house, the studio, the yard, and the water of the bay are all named and thereby appropriated. The letters do the same, quietly settling along the edges of walls and furniture.

III. FORM

Types of Works with Distinct Representation

The form of Maucotel's works is never more important than their meaning. Perhaps because of this fundamental premise, the artist allows himself considerable freedom in handling the materiality of the word. At times it is treated rather casually; at others, with greater care. Sometimes he draws from it an additional beauty beyond the meanings that constitute his primary artistic material, while at other times he allows form to remain merely a means to an end, employed with nothing more than the basic principles of visual culture. He works with a variety of materials, using their physical, visual, and semantic qualities to emphasize meanings and expand the range of contexts in which words operate. These materials include plywood, concrete, wood, found objects, and natural

materials, as in the case of the inscription *Hay*, constructed from bales of hay, which, standing in the yard, simultaneously declares that it is hay, while, by changing the "a" to an "e," says *Hey* to passers-by.

Different kinds of forms convey different moods and states of mind of the artist. The forms of the works fluctuate, arranging themselves into involuntary cycles or formal modes of expressing metaphors and other idiomatic constructions belonging to this distinctive, substantial language.

Types of Works with Distinct Representation

1. In Place of Things or Actions

Suspended Bridge ("suspended bridge")—here the word *Bridge* detaches itself from the ground and appears to extend forward, as though attempting to form a bridge out of itself.

The tangible, wooden word *Bird*, placed inside a cage, replaces the bird itself. It opens the semantic field of the word to encompass every species and kind of bird. Each time the viewer approaches the cage, they may imagine a different bird. The same occurs with the cut-out words *Fish*, placed in an aquarium, and *Rose*, displayed in a vase.

There is also a group of works that replace objects in a more general way, such as the phrase *Still Life*, positioned outside the house. It is, after all, a still life itself while simultaneously signifying one—it "pretends."

2. The Sign of the Cross

Many of the works employ both the symbolism and the form of the cross. They are highly evocative and rooted in the sphere of meanings associated with the cult of Christ.

Thus, in place of the body upon the cross hangs the word *Springtime*.

Around this Christian symbol, further operations are performed upon words: *Simple*, *Mot* (French for "word"), *Crossed Out*, *Time*, and *Onanist*.

In one work, the word *Christ* is crossed out with a small cross, one arm of which extends, once again invoking the symbol of the Passion.

3. Trees

A large number of the works revolve around the motif of trees and wood. One example is *Evergreen*—an inscription whose vertical form, green colour, and carefully chosen proportions make it resemble a tree.

Also belonging to this group are artistic interpretations of the word *Forest* and the work *The Third Tree*. It consists of several vertical wooden forms arranged one behind another. Each has the word *Tree* cut into it, so that the individual words create a rhythm reminiscent of a stand of trees.

4. Theatrical Works

Works that, alongside cut-out letters and words, incorporate representations of people and animals into their compositions include, among others, the highly elaborate *The Punic Wars / Les Guerres puniques* ("The Punic Wars"), recalling a multi-layered theatrical stage set or a model for a shadow theatre.

Stylistically related to *The Punic Wars* is the smaller-scale work *Punic War Leftovers* ("Remnants of the Punic War").

The theme of the Punic Wars was chosen by the artist because it allowed him to play with the English word *pun*.

Other objects resemble models prepared for larger installations, such as *F Taking a Dive* ("F takes a dive"; literally, "F performs a dive into the water"), or, in French, *F plongeant* ("Diving F" or "F Diving").

5. Jokes

Although all of the artist's works employ wit, some are distinguished by a greater lightness, evident both in their formal devices and in the meanings they engage. They radiate an affirmation of life among words, without the slightest doubt as to the value of such pursuits and without deeper existential anxieties.

Here are a few examples of such works. At the edge of the inscription *Hanging on One's Word*, mounted near the ceiling, hangs a cut-out little figure clinging to the letter that forms the word *Word*.

Another small, "domestic phrase" is *What the Hell Is That?!* This universal question demands an explanation for the viewer's hidden thoughts, behaviour, or even existence itself. At the same time, it has the potential to reverse the thrust of its own meaning and ask about the sense of the peculiar, quiet life that a cut-out composed of letters may lead.

Equally charming is the underlined inscription *à la ligne* (French for "to the next line," "to begin a new line").

Or the words enclosed in parentheses: *(entre) (entre) (in between)*. Positioned one after another, they engage in a peculiar bilingual play on the meaning of the word "between."

Up the Wall ("up the wall"; idiomatically also "driven mad," "driven to extremes") naturally climbs up the edge of a wall.

Hanging in There (idiomatically "keep going," "hang in there"; literally "hanging there") rests on a bench in the yard or is suspended inside the house. One may suppose that it would find its place anywhere.

In the French word *Rien* ("nothing"), the letter *R* is so large that it creates an expansive empty space all by itself.

The installation *Understand* consists of the horizontal inscription *Under*, which serves as the physical base for the vertically positioned inscription *Stand*.

The object *Dpressed* (derived from *Depressed*) consists of the letter *D* compressed by a vise. The title itself undergoes compression—deprived of the letter *e*, it becomes the linguistic equivalent of physical pressure.

6. The Influence of Nature

Some of the works give particular consideration to the influence of nature on the creation of meaning, as well as to the way meanings develop over time—usually through processes of

deterioration. These include the objects *Rust*, *Ruin*, the sea-submerged *Oubli* (French for "forgetfulness"), and *Subsculpture*.

Sodit (a neologism composed of the English words *sod* and *it*) consists of two parts. The word *sod* ("turf," "a piece of grass-covered earth") partially sinks into the ground, while the word *it* rises above it. The work carries multiple, contradictory meanings. The expression *sod it* is an English colloquial exclamation meaning roughly "to hell with it!" or "I don't care anymore!" In Hebrew, however, **סוד** (*sod*) means "secret," "hidden knowledge," or "mystical meaning." It is an important concept in Judaism, particularly in Kabbalah. The combination *Sod* + *it* in this context appears especially subversive.

7. The Letter S

Philippe held the letter **S** in special regard. He revered it as a symbol of plurality, or even fertility, because in English it is placed at the end of plural nouns, as in the words *grass* – *grasses*, *tree* – *trees*, *bush* – *bushes*.

The S inspires me (...) because it's a sexy letter, it's a very pregnant letter.

The work *S Door* (a play on the English word *door*) presents a black letter **S** attached to the top of a small door. These are not ordinary household doors, however, but tiny little doors, evoking the world of "**S in Wonderland**."

A mound composed of wooden blocks of various sizes, all shaped like the letter **S**, bears the title *Cauchemard'S / CauchemardeSque / NightmariSh*. The French *cauchemardesque* means "nightmarish," "like a nightmare," while the English *nightmarish* likewise means "nightmarish."

In both words, the letter **S** has been deliberately emphasized as an integral part of each.

Sexy Match is a series of colourful forms resembling zigzagging, dance-like matchsticks.

In this work, Philippe Maucotel entered into a kind of friendly artistic dialogue with the renowned conceptual artist Raymond Hains (1926–2005), who created numerous works employing the form of matchsticks.

Matrix ("matrix," "network," "structure") is a joyful site-specific installation composed of small white letters **S**, freely scattered across a large expanse of lawn.

8. Commemorative Works

The inscription *Momorial* (a neologism combining the English words *mom* and *memorial*, with the subtitle *To All Moms*) is visible only from a bird's-eye view. Seen from the ground, it appears merely as strangely winding paths made of white gravel across the property.

A circle placed on the ground, composed of intersecting capital **As**, pays homage to the Buddha. Meanwhile, crippled, oversized fragments of Roman numerals lying helplessly in the grass form an installation dedicated to Louis XVI.

9. Fences

Fancy ("fancy," "ornate," "fashionable"), proclaims the inscription interrupted by the gaps between the fence pickets. The white fence panel encloses nothing; it stands alone, leaning against the wall of a building—it is enough that it is *Fancy*.

A fragment of an actual functional fence, in turn, invites visitors onto the property with the words *No Stress Passing*. Unlike the customary prohibition—which differs from permission by only a single letter **S**—*No Trespassing* means that entry onto the property is forbidden, while *trespassing* itself denotes unlawful entry onto another person's land or the violation of someone else's property.

Another artistic fence reads: *No Offense*.

This easily recalls *No Fence*, literally meaning "no fence." Or, if we imaginatively add a period after *No*, we obtain *No. of fence*, where *No.* is the abbreviation for *number*. The phrase then means "number of fences" or "fence number"...

10. Postcards

Philippe published an entire series of postcards—photographs of individual works. The transformation of the artist's material language back into a two-dimensional, symbolic form of representation, together with the transformation of the artwork into a letter, further expands the play of puns.

Although publishing postcards reproducing artworks is a common practice among artists, galleries, and museums, in Maucotel's case this gesture seems to carry a wealth of new semantic implications.

11. Large-Scale Spatial Installations, which he jokingly referred to as "Big Art."

The inscription *Momorial* (a play on *Memorial*), discussed earlier, is easy to overlook despite its considerable size. To discover *Momorial*, one must view the world from above, so two wings are necessary, the artist used to say—and without them, imagination, which is always required when experiencing art.

The work *Garbage* is immediately legible and speaks in a straightforward visual language. It consists of an angular, openwork structure filled with rubbish. It refers to the "garbage language" of the contemporary world—the flood of insignificant information and empty messages. Its title contains the wordplay *Gab Age*, which may be read as "the age of gab"—an era of incessant talking in which an excess of words often replaces genuine content. In this way, the rubbish collected inside the structure becomes a metaphor for informational and linguistic chaos, suggesting that the contemporary world is overflowing with worthless chatter and communicative "waste."

IV. MEANING

What else is needed, besides wings, in order to experience Maucotel's art?

A sense of humour, a positive disposition, a willingness to play with words, a sensitivity to the language of poetry, a tolerance for artistic experimentation...

We are dealing with a poet whose work consists in creating new metaphors, testing contexts and the limits of language as a means of communication and a tool of expression. The artist took genuine pleasure in expanding the meanings of words. Perhaps this is why he provided many of the expressions written throughout his domestic surroundings with conditions permanently favourable to the further development of their meanings—even now, long after he himself has departed from our shared reality.

Part of the work he entrusted to the relentless forces of nature, and part to the inhabitants and visitors of the house, the studio, and the garden in Cutchogue.

He created a situation in which the word, the symbol, and reality itself allow poetry to grow.

What is often crucial to the creation of new meanings is the surprise produced by transforming actual presence into the abstract presence of a word, as happens, for example, when the word *Bird* replaces a living bird in a cage, or *Fish* replaces a fish in an aquarium.

The texts also initiate a new life of the materials from which they are made—they propose, as it were, a poetic opening of meaning for those materials.

Language itself—as a vast field of meanings—opens itself to poetry through its encounter with the world and with the viewer. Yet everything in Maucotel's language unfolds with a wink. His works are imbued with good intentions—with the idea of creative play and distance. Concrete materials—wood, plywood, metal—serve the purpose of bringing puns into existence. The artist appears as one who gives life to the play of words.

Does art gain from this? Does it suffer? Art in the service of the mind, of concepts, and of their embodiment through wordplay...

The presence of verbal constructions associated with objects blurs the boundary between visual artists and writers, when the idea carries as much—or even more—importance than the formal, visual structure, leading to conclusions about the dematerialization of art.

The relationship between artist and viewer shifts into the sphere of operations upon meaning, which cannot be compared with painting, sculpture, or printmaking—disciplines that speak in personal languages whose alphabets must always be learned anew, and which exist as independent entities, often expressing through their own visual substance what cannot be expressed in words. In art understood in this way, every element of the work, whether abstract or representational, consists of the smallest artistic particles: unique brushstrokes, touches of the hand—recording the singular physical and psychological dynamics of a particular creator, without the use of letters. Maucotel clearly distances himself from this kind of articulation—his model of art is intentional.

Artistic strategies based on words often lead to questioning the very meaning of contemporary art. Yet language and ideas have been treated as artistic media by many artists.

Maucotel himself drifts toward the negation of form and meaning. It seems that the commodification of art angers him. *Whether people buy it or not, you have to be inspired*, he remarked.

Perhaps this is why, in his idealism, he went so far as to prepare an exhibition that never took place. *No Show Show* is a form of post-conceptual practice in which art occurs without an artwork—and even without its theoretical concept. *Désœuvrement* (French for "idleness," "the state of being without a work," "withdrawal from action") proclaimed the inscription on the beautiful red invitation cards. Beneath it appeared the note: *or I can't stand it any more*. The meeting with the artist took place in the empty Kurier Plus Gallery in New York. Philippe attended the opening. There were wonderful refreshments, wine, and everyone had a good time, but no one viewed the exhibition, because there was no exhibition.

V. THE EXHIBITION THAT NEVER WAS – THE ARTIST WHO NEVER WAS

Philippe Tougaard-Maucotel participated in exhibitions of artists devoted to the play of words. Yet he also treated the exhibitions in which he took part as a form of play and as acts of establishing the concept of himself as an artist. He played with his own artistic persona.

When he organized *Désœuvrement*, he became a post-conceptualist. He also exhibited sculptures in public spaces, for example in parks, alongside the works of sculptors, and then he could be described as a sculptor. The intimate, tiny inscriptions accompanying interior architecture and domestic objects make him a modest poet. Joint exhibitions with well-known artists allow him to be perceived as an international artist...

On the lawn of his own property, he sometimes becomes a performance artist. He playfully subverts the definition of his own existence, as though he had invented himself only to annihilate himself a moment later.

He is still smiling and continuing the game—now he becomes visible, although just a moment ago he was not there.